



Correlational Study on Dark Triad Personality Traits and Money Management Behaviour

DISSERTATION

Submitted in Partial Fulfilment of the Requirements for the Degree of

M.A. PSYCHOLOGY

Submitted By

AAHELI ADHIKARY

Registration No: XK01-2112-0765-23

Batch: 2024-2026

Under the Supervision of:

Dr. Anurupa Kundu

Department of Psychology

Faculty of Arts and Social Studies

St. XAVIER'S UNIVERSITY KOLKATA

2025

CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the dissertation titled “**Correlational Study on Dark Triad Personality Traits and Money Management Behaviour**” is a bonafide work carried out by **Aaheli Adhikary**, a student of the **M.A. Psychology (2024–2026 batch)** at **St. Xavier’s University, Kolkata**, under my supervision and guidance.

This is further to certify that the work submitted by the candidate in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of **Master of Arts in Psychology** has not formed the basis for the award of any degree, diploma, or similar title to any other candidate. This dissertation is a record of the candidate’s independent work and personal effort. It has been run through the University’s prescribed plagiarism detection software and its similarity score is 0% which is within the stipulated limit.

Signature of Guide: _____

Forwarded by: _____

Dr. Anurupa Kundu

(Assistant Professor)

Department of Psychology

St. Xavier’s University, Kolkata

Dr. Jhilli Das (Tewary)

(Associate Professor & Head)

Department of Psychology

St. Xavier’s University, Kolkata

Professor Dr. Susmita Halder

(Dean of Arts and Social Studies)

St. Xavier’s University, Kolkata

DECLARATION

Paper Title: Correlational Study on Dark Triad Personality Traits and Money Management Behaviour

Department: Psychology

Semester: IV

Paper Code: MPR440J

Name of Student: Aaheli Adhikary

Roll No.: 0055

Date of submission of Dissertation: 06. 05. 2026

Declaration by the Student

I affirm that, to the best of my knowledge, I have identified all my sources and that no part of my dissertation paper contains any unacknowledged material.

Signature of the Student

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Topic	Page no.
Acknowledgement	5
Abstract	6
Introduction	7-9
Review of Literature	10-14
Methodology	15-20
Results	21-24
Discussion	25-28
Conclusion, Limitation & Implications	28-31
References	32-33
Appendices	34-44

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to all those who have supported and guided me throughout the completion of this dissertation.

I am highly indebted to my guide, **Dr. Anurupa Kundu**, for her invaluable guidance, constant supervision, and continuous encouragement. Her insightful suggestions, patience, and support played a crucial role in shaping this research and bringing it to completion.

I would also like to extend my heartfelt gratitude to the Head of the Department, **Dr. Jhilli Das (Tewary)**, and all my professors at **St. Xavier's University, Kolkata**, for their academic support and encouragement throughout my postgraduate journey.

I am deeply grateful to my mother, **Mrs. Enakshi Adhikary**, for her unwavering support, motivation, and belief in me, which helped me overcome challenges during this process.

I would also like to thank my friends, both in Kolkata and outside, for their cooperation, encouragement, and emotional support. Special thanks to the participants of **Crizac Limited** and **Ms. Shurbhi Mundhra** for providing me with the opportunity to collect data from the organization and for their valuable cooperation in this study.

Finally, I would like to thank everyone who directly or indirectly contributed to the completion of this dissertation within the given time frame.

AAHELI ADHIKARY,

Registration No: XK01-2112-0765-23,

Student, M.A. Psychology,

Semester: 4, Batch: 2024-2026

Department of Psychology,

Faculty of Arts and Social Studies,

St. Xavier's University, Kolkata.

ABSTRACT

Money isn't just about its economic value; it also carries strong psychological meaning. For many people, it represents power, control, security, and even emotional satisfaction. However, individuals differ in how they think about and handle money, and these differences often reflect deeper personality traits and unconscious tendencies.

This study explores how the Dark Triad personality traits (Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy) are related to attitudes and behaviours toward money. In particular, it focuses on how money is experienced symbolically, such as in terms of power, burden, and hoarding.

The study adopted a quantitative, correlational design and was conducted with young adults between the ages of 23 and 30. Data were collected using the Short Dark Triad (SD3) scale along with an adapted Money Attitude questionnaire that measured dimensions such as power-prestige, retention-time, distrust, anxiety, materialism, and hoarding. Mean scores were calculated for all variables, and the data were analysed using descriptive statistics and Pearson's correlation.

The findings suggest that individuals with higher levels of Dark Triad traits tend to view money as a source of power and status. At the same time, their financial behaviours reflect differing degrees of anxiety and a need for control. These results point to the influence of personality in shaping how people relate to money and highlight the importance of considering the deeper, often unconscious meanings attached to it. Overall, the study adds to the growing literature on the psychology of money by bringing together both personality-based and symbolic perspectives.

Keywords: Dark Triad Traits, Money Attitudes, Financial Behaviour, Power–Prestige, Money Anxiety, Hoarding

INTRODUCTION

Money is a central part of everyday life, shaping not only economic choices but also psychological experiences and social relationships. Although it is commonly understood as a medium of exchange, money carries meanings that go far beyond its economic function. People often associate it with ideas such as power, control, security, freedom, and even love, making it an important psychological construct rather than just a financial resource (Furnham & Argyle, 1998; Lea & Webley, 2006).

The way individuals perceive and manage money varies considerably and is influenced by their values, life experiences, and personality. In contemporary consumer-oriented societies, money is closely linked to identity and self-worth. Many individuals evaluate their success and social position based on financial status and material possessions. This tendency is closely linked to materialism, a value orientation in which individuals place significant importance on acquiring wealth and possessions as a source of happiness and life satisfaction (Richins & Dawson, 1992). Such beliefs can shape spending habits, saving behaviour, and overall financial decision-making.

Personality plays an important role in shaping attitudes toward money. Among the various personality frameworks, the Dark Triad traits: Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy, have received considerable attention for their association with socially aversive behaviours (Paulhus & Williams, 2002). Individuals high in Machiavellianism are often strategic and manipulative, using resources like money to influence others. Narcissistic individuals tend to seek admiration and status, often linking money with prestige and self-enhancement. In contrast, individuals with higher psychopathic traits, characterized by impulsivity and low empathy, may engage in risky financial behaviours with little regard for long-term consequences.

Beyond conscious attitudes, money also operates at a deeper, often unconscious level. From a psychodynamic viewpoint, money may function as a symbolic representation of underlying psychological needs, including a desire for control, a sense of security, and emotional satisfaction (Belk & Wallendorf, 1990). For some individuals, it represents power and the ability to assert dominance or gain validation. For others, money may be experienced as a burden, associated with anxiety, responsibility, or fear of loss. In some cases, individuals may develop hoarding tendencies, accumulating money or possessions as a way of coping with insecurity and uncertainty.

These underlying meanings influence financial behaviour in complex ways. For example, some individuals may overspend as a way of seeking approval or managing emotional discomfort, while others may engage in excessive saving or hoarding due to fears of scarcity. Such patterns highlight the interaction between personality traits and emotional processes in shaping money-related attitudes and behaviours.

Despite increasing interest in financial behaviour, much of the existing research has examined personality traits and money attitudes separately. There is limited work that integrates these perspectives, particularly in understanding how Dark Triad traits relate to the symbolic and unconscious meanings of money. Exploring this relationship is especially relevant in a context where financial decisions are closely tied to identity, emotional well-being, and social dynamics.

Therefore, the present study aims to examine the relationship between Dark Triad personality traits and money attitudes, with a particular focus on the symbolic dimensions of money as power, burden, and hoarding. By bringing together personality and psychological perspectives, the study seeks to offer a more comprehensive understanding of the factors that shape financial behaviour.

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

The understanding of money within psychology has gradually shifted from a purely economic perspective to a more nuanced view that includes emotional, symbolic, and personality-based dimensions. Researchers have increasingly emphasized that money is not simply a medium of exchange, but a psychological object shaped by individual experiences, beliefs, and personality traits. The present section reviews key literature on the psychological meaning of money, money attitudes, Dark Triad personality traits, materialism, and the unconscious dimensions associated with money.

Psychological Meaning of Money

Money has long been recognized as a construct that carries subjective meanings beyond its functional role. Early work by Adrian Furnham (1984) highlighted that people develop distinct attitudes toward money based on their upbringing, cultural context, and personality. He proposed that money is often associated with feelings of **power, security, anxiety, and control**, suggesting that individuals do not relate to money in a uniform manner.

Building on this, Thomas Li-Ping Tang (1992) argued that money represents more than material wealth; it symbolizes **achievement, recognition, and personal success**. His findings indicated that individuals' beliefs about money can influence not only their financial decisions but also their work attitudes, ethical choices, and overall life satisfaction.

Taken together, these studies suggest that money functions as a **psychological symbol**, reflecting deeper emotional needs and cognitive evaluations rather than merely serving economic purposes.

Money Attitudes and Behaviour

The study of money attitudes gained structure with the development of the **Money Attitude Scale (MAS)** by Yamauchi and Kiyoshi Templer (1982). This model identified four major dimensions: **power–prestige, retention–time, distrust, and anxiety**, which together explain how individuals think about and interact with money.

People who score high on **power–prestige** tend to use money as a way to assert status and gain social recognition. In contrast, those high on **retention–time** are more future-oriented, demonstrating careful planning and saving behaviours. The **distrust** dimension reflects

skepticism and caution in financial matters, while **anxiety** captures the emotional tension and worry associated with money.

Subsequent research has consistently shown that these attitudes are closely linked to actual financial behaviours. For example, individuals who prioritize retention are more likely to engage in responsible financial practices, whereas those experiencing higher anxiety often report financial stress and instability (Furnham, 1984; Tang, 1992). These findings reinforce the idea that **how people feel about money directly influences how they manage it**.

Dark Triad Personality Traits

The concept of the **Dark Triad**, introduced by Delroy L. Paulhus and Kevin M. Williams (2002), brought attention to three personality traits that are socially aversive yet commonly found in non-clinical populations: Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy.

Machiavellianism involves strategic manipulation and a tendency to exploit others for personal gain. Narcissism is characterized by a strong need for admiration, inflated self-importance, and a desire for status. Psychopathy, on the other hand, is associated with impulsivity, lack of empathy, and disregard for consequences. Individuals high on these traits often prioritize self-interest and may engage in unethical or risk-taking behaviours.

To measure these traits more efficiently, Daniel N. Jones and Paulhus (2014) developed the **Short Dark Triad (SD3)**. Research using this scale suggests that individuals high in Dark Triad traits are more likely to engage in **financially exploitative or status-driven behaviours**, viewing money as a tool for achieving personal advantage.

Materialism and Financial Behaviour

Materialism has been identified as a key factor influencing how individuals relate to money. Russell W. Belk (1985) described materialism as the tendency to view possessions as central to one's identity and life satisfaction. According to this perspective, individuals use material goods to construct and express their sense of self.

Empirical research has shown that highly materialistic individuals are more prone to **compulsive buying, overspending, and financial dissatisfaction**. Rather than leading to long-term happiness, excessive materialism is often associated with lower psychological

well-being and increased financial stress. This suggests that the pursuit of wealth and possessions may reflect deeper emotional needs rather than genuine satisfaction.

Thus, materialism plays an important role in shaping financial behaviour, particularly in contexts where money is closely linked to identity and social comparison.

Unconscious and Symbolic Meaning of Money

From a psychodynamic perspective, money is deeply intertwined with unconscious processes. Sigmund Freud (1908/1959) suggested that money can symbolically represent **control, power, and even repressed desires**. Later theorists expanded this view, proposing that money may act as a substitute for emotional needs such as **love, security, and self-worth**.

This perspective helps explain why individuals sometimes behave irrationally with money. For instance, excessive saving or hoarding may reflect a fear of loss or insecurity, while impulsive spending may serve as a way to cope with emotional distress or seek validation.

Understanding money from an unconscious perspective highlights that financial behaviours are often driven by **emotional and psychological factors that individuals may not be fully aware of**.

Money as Power, Burden, and Hoarding

Research suggests that people experience money in fundamentally different ways. For some individuals, money is closely linked to **power and control**, allowing them to influence others and enhance their social standing. This is particularly relevant for individuals high in narcissistic and Machiavellian traits, who may use money as a means of asserting dominance. On the other hand, money can also be experienced as a **burden**, associated with stress, responsibility, and anxiety. Financial concerns often lead to emotional strain, affecting both decision-making and overall well-being.

Hoarding represents another important dimension, where individuals accumulate money or possessions as a way to create a sense of **security and stability**. Such behaviour is often driven by fear of uncertainty and reflects deeper psychological needs for control and safety.

These dimensions: power, burden, and hoarding, highlight the complex and often contradictory ways in which individuals relate to money.

Research Gap

While existing research has provided valuable insights into money attitudes, materialism, and Dark Triad personality traits, these variables have largely been studied in isolation. There is limited research that integrates these constructs within a single framework.

In particular, the **unconscious symbolic meanings of money**, such as power, burden, and hoarding, have not been adequately explored in relation to personality traits. Understanding how these dimensions interact is essential for developing a more comprehensive view of financial behaviour.

Therefore, the present study aims to bridge this gap by examining how **Dark Triad personality traits influence money attitudes and behaviours**, with a focus on the underlying psychological meanings attached to money.

METHODOLOGY

OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY

The present study aims to examine the **correlation between Dark Triad personality traits and money-related attitudes and behaviours**. The specific objectives are:

- To assess the level of **Dark Triad personality traits** (Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy) among the participants.
- To assess the level of **money attitudes**, including dimensions such as power–prestige, retention–time, distrust, materialism, anxiety, and hoarding.
- To assess the **correlation between Dark Triad personality traits and money attitudes**.

HYPOTHESIS

Dark Triad traits will be significantly related to different dimensions of money attitudes (e.g., power-prestige, anxiety, and hoarding).

RESEARCH DESIGN

The present study adopted **quantitative, correlational research design** to examine the correlation between Dark Triad personality traits, materialistic values, and financial management behaviour. This design was considered appropriate as the study aimed to assess the degree and direction of association between variables without manipulating them.

SAMPLE

The study was conducted on a sample of **young adults aged between 23 and 30 years**, as this age group represents a critical phase of developing financial independence and identity formation.

A total of approximately **100–130 participants** were included in the study. Participants were selected using a **convenience sampling method**, based on accessibility and willingness to participate. The sample included individuals from different educational backgrounds (undergraduate and postgraduate students) and occupational statuses.

Participants were recruited **in-person data collection** in organizational setting. Individuals who provided informed consent and completed the questionnaire were included in the study.

Inclusion Criteria

The following criteria were used to select participants for the study:

- **Age Range (23–30 years):** Only young adults within this age group were included, as this stage is associated with increasing financial independence and decision-making responsibilities.
- **Ability to Understand the Questionnaire:** Participants were required to have sufficient comprehension skills to understand and respond to the items in English, ensuring the accuracy and reliability of responses.
- **Willingness to Participate:** Only those individuals who voluntarily agreed to participate and provided informed consent were included in the study.

Exclusion Criteria

The following criteria were used to exclude participants from the study:

- **Incomplete Responses:** Questionnaires with missing or incomplete data were excluded to maintain the quality and accuracy of the analysis.
- **Lack of Consent:** Individuals who did not provide informed consent or withdrew during the study were excluded.
- **Inconsistent or Random Responses:** Responses that appeared inconsistent or careless were not considered for analysis to ensure data reliability.

Ethical Considerations

The present study adhered to standard ethical principles of psychological research.

- **Informed Consent:** Participants were informed about the purpose and nature of the study, and consent was obtained prior to participation.
- **Voluntary Participation:** Participation was entirely voluntary, and participants were free to withdraw from the study at any time without any penalty.
- **Confidentiality:** The information provided by participants was kept strictly confidential and used only for research purposes.

- **Anonymity:** No personally identifiable information was collected, ensuring that participants remained anonymous.
- **No Harm:** The study did not involve any physical or psychological harm, and the questionnaire consisted of non-invasive items.
- **Right to Withdraw:** Participants had the right to discontinue participation at any stage of the study.
- **Use of Data:** The collected data were used solely for academic purposes and were not shared with any unauthorized individuals.

VARIABLES

Independent Variable

- **Dark Triad Traits:** Dark Triad traits refer to a cluster of socially aversive personality characteristics, namely **Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy**. These traits were operationally defined as the scores obtained by participants on the **Short Dark Triad (SD3)** scale. Higher scores indicate a greater presence of manipulative, self-centered, and impulsive tendencies.

Dependent Variables

- **Materialistic Values:** Materialistic values refer to the extent to which individuals prioritize material possessions and wealth as central to their happiness and success. This was measured using selected items from the money attitude questionnaire reflecting materialistic orientation.
- **Financial Management Behaviour:** Financial management behaviour refers to the way individuals manage their financial resources, including planning, saving, budgeting, and spending habits. It was operationally defined through responses to relevant items reflecting retention, control, and saving behaviour.

TOOLS / MEASURES

1. Short Dark Triad (SD3)

Developed by Jones and Paulhus (2014), the SD3 is a widely used self-report measure consisting of **27 items**, with 9 items each assessing Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy. Participants respond on a **5-point Likert scale** ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree).

The scale has demonstrated adequate reliability and validity in non-clinical populations and is suitable for assessing socially aversive personality traits in young adults.

2. Money Attitude Questionnaire (Adapted)

An adapted version of the Money Attitude Scale originally developed by Yamauchi and Templer (1982) was used to assess participants' attitudes and behaviours related to money.

The questionnaire consisted of **29 items**, measured on a **7-point Likert scale** ranging from 1 (never) to 7 (always). Based on conceptual grouping, the scale was divided into the following dimensions:

- **Power–Prestige** (use of money for status and influence)
- **Retention–Time** (planning and saving behaviour)
- **Distrust** (cautious financial attitude)
- **Anxiety** (emotional stress related to money)
- **Materialism** (importance of possessions and wealth)
- **Hoarding** (tendency to accumulate and avoid spending)

Mean scores were calculated for each subscale, as well as an overall money attitude score.

PROCEDURE

Prior to data collection, participants were informed about the purpose and nature of the study. Informed consent was obtained, and participants were assured that their participation was **voluntary** and that they could withdraw at any time without penalty.

The questionnaire was administered through **offline modes** in an organizational setting. Participants were instructed to respond honestly based on their typical thoughts and behaviours.

Confidentiality and anonymity were strictly maintained. No personally identifiable information was collected, and the data were used solely for academic purposes.

STATISTICAL ANALYSIS

The collected data were analysed using appropriate statistical techniques.

- **Descriptive statistics** such as **mean** and **standard deviation** were computed to summarize the data and understand the distribution of variables.
- **Pearson's product-moment correlation** was used to examine the **correlation** between Dark Triad traits, materialistic values, and financial management behaviour. This test was selected as it assesses the **strength** and **direction** of linear associations between continuous variables.

All analyses were conducted to test the stated hypotheses and to understand the underlying associations among the variables.

RESULTS

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics (N = 130)

Variable	Mean	SD
Machiavellianism	29.8	5.29
Narcissism	28.3	5.21
Psychopathy	21.5	5.54
Dark Triad Total	79.6	10.9
Power–Prestige	20.2	8.71
Retention–Time	30.7	8.61
Distrust	18.1	4.37
Materialism	11.8	4.20
Anxiety	22.5	8.36
Hoarding	13.3	3.80
Money Total	117	23.4

Descriptive statistics were computed to examine the distribution of the study variables. The mean score for Machiavellianism was 29.8 (SD = 5.29), for narcissism was 28.3 (SD = 5.21), and for psychopathy was 21.5 (SD = 5.54). The overall Dark Triad total had a mean of 79.6 (SD = 10.9).

Among the money-related variables, retention–time had the highest mean score (M = 30.7, SD = 8.61), followed by anxiety (M = 22.5, SD = 8.36) and power–prestige (M = 20.2, SD = 8.71). The overall money attitude score (money total) had a mean of 117 (SD = 23.4).

Table 2: Pearson Correlation Matrix among Dark Triad Traits and Money Attitude Variables

Variables	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
1. Machiavellianism	—										
2. Narcissism	.291* **	—									
3. Psychopathy	.209* **	.070	—								
4. Dark Triad Total	.733* **	.657* **	.645* **	—							
5. Power–Prestige	.315* **	.142	.360* **	.405* **	—						
6. Retention–Time	.094	.055	-.196* *	-.027	-.003	—					
7. Distrust	.125	-.050	.028	.051	.253* *	.342* **	—				
8. Materialism	.267* *	.163	.132	.275* *	.488* **	.138	.111	—			
9. Anxiety	.191* *	.015	.261* *	.233* *	.513* **	.038	.295* **	.249* *	—		
10. Hoarding	.280* *	.081	.037	.194* *	.184* *	.292* **	.167	.055	.350* **	—	
11. Money Total	.337* **	.112	.190* *	.315* **	.721* **	.518* **	.560* **	.531* **	.720* **	.505* **	—

Note. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Pearson's product-moment correlation was conducted to examine the relationships among Dark Triad traits and money-related variables (see Table X).

The results indicated that Machiavellianism was significantly positively correlated with narcissism ($r = .291, p < .001$) and psychopathy ($r = .209, p < .05$). However, narcissism and psychopathy were not significantly correlated.

Dark Triad total scores were strongly positively correlated with Machiavellianism ($r = .733, p < .001$), narcissism ($r = .657, p < .001$), and psychopathy ($r = .645, p < .001$).

With respect to money attitudes, Dark Triad traits showed significant positive correlations with power–prestige ($r = .405, p < .001$), materialism ($r = .275, p < .01$), anxiety ($r = .233, p < .01$), hoarding ($r = .194, p < .05$), and money total ($r = .315, p < .001$). No significant relationships were found with retention–time and distrust.

Machiavellianism was significantly positively correlated with power–prestige ($r = .315, p < .001$), materialism ($r = .267, p < .01$), anxiety ($r = .191, p < .05$), hoarding ($r = .280, p < .01$), and money total ($r = .337, p < .001$).

Psychopathy showed significant positive correlations with power–prestige ($r = .360, p < .001$), anxiety ($r = .261, p < .01$), and money total ($r = .190, p < .05$), and a significant negative correlation with retention–time ($r = -.196, p < .05$).

Narcissism did not show significant relationships with most money-related variable.

Among money variables, power–prestige was significantly positively correlated with materialism ($r = .488, p < .001$) and anxiety ($r = .513, p < .001$). Retention–time was significantly correlated with distrust ($r = .342, p < .001$) and hoarding ($r = .292, p < .001$). Anxiety was also significantly correlated with hoarding ($r = .350, p < .001$).

DISCUSSION

The present study aimed to assess the levels of Dark Triad personality traits and money attitudes, and to examine the correlation between these variables. The findings indicated that participants exhibited moderate levels of Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy, suggesting that these traits are present in the general population in non-extreme forms. Similarly, money attitudes varied across dimensions, with relatively higher mean scores observed for retention–time and anxiety. This suggests that participants not only engage in financial planning but also experience emotional involvement in money-related matters. These findings address the first two objectives of the study by establishing that both personality traits and money attitudes are meaningfully present and measurable within the sample.

With regard to the third objective, the correlation analysis revealed significant associations between Dark Triad traits and several dimensions of money attitudes. In particular, Dark Triad traits were positively correlated with power–prestige, indicating that individuals high in Machiavellianism and psychopathy are more likely to perceive money as a means of gaining influence, authority, and social status. This finding is consistent with the theoretical understanding of Machiavellianism as a trait characterized by strategic manipulation and a desire for control (Paulhus & Williams, 2002). Individuals high in such traits may use money as a resource to navigate social hierarchies and exert dominance. Similarly, Tang (1992) proposed that money functions as a symbol of success and power, which aligns with the present findings.

The study also found a significant positive association between Dark Triad traits and materialism, suggesting that individuals with higher levels of these traits tend to place greater importance on material possessions as indicators of success and self-worth. This is consistent with the work of Richins and Dawson (1992), who conceptualized materialism as a value orientation in which possessions play a central role in identity formation. The relatively stronger role of Machiavellianism compared to narcissism in the present findings suggests that strategic and control-oriented tendencies may be more closely linked with material pursuits than self-enhancement motives alone.

Another important finding was the significant correlation between Dark Triad traits and money-related anxiety. This suggests that individuals who associate money with power and success may also experience greater emotional involvement or concern regarding financial matters. Although Dark Triad traits are often associated with emotional detachment, the

present findings indicate that money may act as a psychologically significant construct that evokes both control and insecurity. This supports Furnham's (1984) view that money carries emotional meanings and can be a source of anxiety and psychological tension.

The positive association between Dark Triad traits and hoarding further supports this interpretation. Hoarding behaviour may reflect a tendency toward accumulation as a means of maintaining control, ensuring security, or reducing uncertainty. From a psychodynamic perspective, such behaviours may be understood as symbolic expressions of deeper psychological needs related to control and stability (Freud, 1908/1959). In this context, money and possessions may function as tools for psychological regulation rather than purely economic resources.

In contrast, no significant relationship was found between Dark Triad traits and retention–time, indicating that these traits are not associated with long-term financial planning or disciplined saving behaviour. The negative correlation between psychopathy and retention–time further suggests that individuals high in psychopathic traits may exhibit impulsive financial tendencies and a lack of future orientation. This finding is consistent with existing literature that characterizes psychopathy by impulsivity, risk-taking, and poor behavioural regulation (Jones & Paulhus, 2014).

The interrelationships among money attitude variables also provide important insights into the structure of money attitudes. Power–prestige was strongly associated with materialism and anxiety, suggesting that individuals who view money as a symbol of status are also emotionally invested in it. Similarly, retention–time was positively associated with distrust and hoarding, indicating that financial planning is linked with cautious and controlled financial behaviour. These findings are consistent with the multidimensional framework of money attitudes proposed by Yamauchi and Templer (1982), which highlights the interaction between cognitive, behavioural, and emotional aspects of money.

Overall, the findings of the present study support the conceptualization of money as a complex psychological construct shaped by personality traits and emotional processes. Dark Triad traits, particularly Machiavellianism and psychopathy, appear to play a significant role in influencing how individuals perceive and use money in terms of power, control, and emotional engagement. The study contributes to the growing field of money psychology by demonstrating that financial attitudes are not purely rational or economic, but are deeply

embedded in personality structures and symbolic meanings. Furthermore, the findings extend existing research by highlighting how socially aversive traits influence not only interpersonal dynamics but also financial attitudes and behaviours.

CONCLUSION

The present study aimed to explore the relationship between Dark Triad personality traits and money-related attitudes, with a focus on the symbolic meanings associated with money, such as power, materialism, anxiety, and hoarding. The findings revealed that Dark Triad traits are significantly associated with multiple dimensions of money attitudes, indicating that personality plays an important role in shaping how individuals perceive and use money.

The results demonstrated that individuals high in Dark Triad traits tend to associate money with power, status, and emotional significance. They are more likely to exhibit materialistic tendencies, experience financial anxiety, and engage in hoarding behaviours. At the same time, these traits were not associated with long-term financial planning, suggesting a lack of future-oriented financial behaviour, particularly among individuals high in psychopathy.

Overall, the study highlights that money is not merely an economic resource but a psychological construct deeply influenced by personality traits and emotional processes. The findings contribute to a better understanding of how socially aversive personality traits influence financial attitudes and behaviours, particularly in terms of control, security, and emotional regulation.

LIMITATIONS

Despite its contributions, the present study has certain limitations that should be acknowledged.

Firstly, the study employed a **convenience sampling method**, and the sample consisted of **130 participants**, which, although adequate for Pearson's correlation analysis, may limit the generalizability of the findings to a wider population. A larger and more diverse sample could enhance the external validity of the results.

Secondly, the study was conducted within a **limited time frame**, which may have restricted the scope of data collection and the inclusion of a more diverse participant pool. A longer

duration could allow for more comprehensive data collection and deeper exploration of the variables.

Thirdly, the study relied on **self-report measures**, which are subject to response biases such as social desirability and subjective interpretation. This is particularly relevant when assessing socially sensitive traits such as Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy.

Fourthly, the research followed a **cross-sectional design**, which limits the ability to establish causal relationships between variables. While the findings indicate significant correlations, the directionality of these relationships cannot be determined.

Additionally, money attitudes are influenced by various contextual factors such as **socio-economic status, financial literacy, cultural influences, and individual life experiences**, which were not controlled for in the present study. These factors may have shaped participants' financial attitudes and behaviours, thereby influencing the results.

IMPLICATIONS

The findings of the study have several important theoretical and practical implications.

From a theoretical perspective, the study contributes to the field of **money psychology** by highlighting the role of personality traits, particularly Dark Triad traits, in shaping financial attitudes and behaviours. It supports the view that money carries symbolic and emotional meanings beyond its economic function.

From a practical perspective, the study has implications for **financial behaviour and awareness**. Understanding how personality traits influence money attitudes can help in developing more personalized approaches to financial education and management. For instance, individuals high in impulsivity or dominance-oriented traits may benefit from interventions focused on improving financial planning and emotional regulation.

The findings may also be relevant in **organizational and workplace settings**, where financial decision-making and ethical behaviour are important. Awareness of personality influences can help in identifying potential risk factors related to financial misuse or unethical practices.

Furthermore, the study has implications for **counselling and psychological interventions**, particularly in helping individuals understand their relationship with money and addressing maladaptive financial behaviours such as excessive spending or hoarding.

FUTURE DIRECTIONS

Future research can build upon the present study in several meaningful ways.

Firstly, future studies may consider using a **larger and more diverse sample**, including participants from different age groups, cultural backgrounds, and socio-economic statuses. This would enhance the generalizability of findings and provide a broader understanding of how personality traits influence money attitudes across populations.

Secondly, researchers can adopt a **longitudinal research design** to examine how the relationship between Dark Triad traits and money attitudes evolves over time. This would help in understanding the directionality and stability of these relationships, which cannot be determined through cross-sectional data.

Thirdly, future research may incorporate additional variables such as **financial literacy, income level, occupational status, and cultural values**, as these factors are likely to influence money-related attitudes and behaviours.

Further, the use of **mixed methods approaches**, combining quantitative measures with qualitative insights (such as interviews), could provide a deeper understanding of the psychological meanings individuals attach to money.

Additionally, future studies may explore the role of **interventions or financial education programs** in modifying money attitudes, particularly among individuals exhibiting higher levels of impulsivity or materialism.

Finally, research can also examine the **practical implications in organizational and financial settings**, such as how personality traits influence financial decision-making, ethical behaviour, and risk-taking.

IMPLICATIONS

The findings of the present study have important theoretical, practical, and applied implications.

From a **theoretical perspective**, the study contributes to the growing field of money psychology by demonstrating that money is not merely an economic resource but a psychological construct influenced by personality traits. The significant correlations between Dark Triad traits and money attitudes highlight how socially aversive personality characteristics shape individuals' perceptions of money in terms of power, control, and emotional significance. This adds to existing literature by integrating personality theory with financial behaviour research.

From a **practical perspective**, the findings can be useful in understanding individual differences in financial behaviour. Recognizing that traits such as Machiavellianism and psychopathy are associated with power-oriented and emotionally driven money attitudes can help in developing more personalized approaches to financial awareness and education. Individuals who exhibit impulsive or control-driven tendencies may benefit from targeted strategies that promote financial planning and emotional regulation.

The study also has implications for **financial counselling and psychological interventions**. Understanding the emotional and symbolic meanings attached to money can help professionals identify maladaptive financial behaviours such as excessive spending, hoarding, or anxiety related to money. Interventions can be designed to address these underlying psychological patterns rather than focusing solely on financial outcomes.

In **organizational and workplace settings**, the findings may help in understanding how personality traits influence financial decision-making, ethical behaviour, and resource management. Awareness of such traits can be useful in roles that involve financial responsibility, negotiation, or leadership, where money-related decisions are critical.

Finally, the study highlights the importance of considering **psychological and emotional factors in financial behaviour**, suggesting that financial decisions are not purely rational but are influenced by deeper personality dynamics. This perspective can inform future research, policy-making, and educational programs aimed at improving financial well-being.

REFERENCES

- Ajzen, I. (1991). The theory of planned behavior. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*, 50(2), 179–211.
- Buss, D. M. (1991). Evolutionary personality psychology. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 42, 459–491.
- Christopher, A. N., Marek, P., & Carroll, S. M. (2004). Materialism and attitudes toward money: An exploratory investigation. *Individual Differences Research*, 2(2), 109–117.
- Dittmar, H. (2005). Compulsive buying—a growing concern? *Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology*, 24(6), 832–859.
- Dittmar, H., Bond, R., Hurst, M., & Kasser, T. (2014). The relationship between materialism and personal well-being. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 107(5), 879–924.
- Furnham, A., & Okamura, R. (1999). Your money or your life: Behavioral and emotional predictors of money pathology. *Human Relations*, 52(9), 1157–1177.
- Kasser, T. (2002). *The high price of materialism*. MIT Press.
- Kasser, T., & Ryan, R. M. (1993). A dark side of the American dream: Correlates of financial success as a central life aspiration. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 65(2), 410–422.
- Kirkcaldy, B., & Furnham, A. (1993). Predictors of beliefs about money. *Psychological Reports*, 73(3), 1079–1082.
- Lea, S. E. G., & Webley, P. (2006). Money as tool, money as drug: The biological psychology of a strong incentive. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 29(2), 161–176.
- Mowen, J. C., & Spears, N. (1999). Understanding compulsive buying. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, 8(4), 407–430.
- Roberts, J. A., & Jones, E. (2001). Money attitudes, credit card use, and compulsive buying. *Journal of Consumer Affairs*, 35(2), 213–240.

- Rook, D. W. (1987). The buying impulse. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 14(2), 189–199.
- Tang, T. L. P., & Chiu, R. K. (2003). Income, money ethic, pay satisfaction, commitment, and unethical behavior. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 43(1–2), 13–30.
- Tang, T. L. P., Luna-Arocas, R., Sutarso, T., & Tang, D. S. H. (2004). Does the love of money moderate and mediate the income-pay satisfaction relationship? *Journal of Managerial Psychology*, 19(2), 111–135.
- Twenge, J. M., & Campbell, W. K. (2009). *The narcissism epidemic: Living in the age of entitlement*. Free Press.
- Vohs, K. D., Mead, N. L., & Goode, M. R. (2006). The psychological consequences of money. *Science*, 314(5802), 1154–1156.
- Watson, P. J. (2003). The relationship of materialism to spending tendencies. *Journal of Economic Psychology*, 24(6), 723–739.
- Webley, P., & Nyhus, E. K. (2006). Parents' influence on children's future orientation. *Journal of Economic Psychology*, 27(1), 140–164.
- Zhang, L. (2013). Money attitude and financial behavior. *Journal of Behavioral and Experimental Economics*, 47, 106–112.

APPENDICES

Appendix A: Informed Consent Form for Participants

Title of the Study: The Influence of Dark Triad Personality Traits on Money Management Behaviour

Investigator: Aaheli Adhikary **Guide:** Dr. Anurupa Kundu / anurupa.kundu@sxuk.edu.in

Institution/Organization: St. Xavier's University, Kolkata; **Faculty of Arts and Social Studies,** **The** **Department** **of** **Psychology**

Contact Details: 7980837179 / aaheli.mindatwork@gmail.com

Purpose of the Study:

The purpose of the present study is to examine the influence of Dark Triad personality traits, namely Machiavellianism, Narcissism, and Psychopathy on money management behaviour among young adults. The study seeks to understand how individual differences in these personality traits are associated with attitudes toward money, including spending, saving, planning, financial anxiety, and the use of money as a means of influence or status.

By exploring the relationship between personality traits and money-related behaviours, the study aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of psychological factors that shape financial decision-making. The findings may help in identifying personality-based patterns in money management, which can be useful for developing targeted financial education, counselling, and interventions to promote healthier financial behaviours and overall well-being.

Participation Details:

- Your participation is entirely voluntary.
- You will be asked to respond to a questionnaire that will take approximately 15-20 minutes to complete.
- You may choose to withdraw at any point without any penalty.
- Your responses will be kept strictly confidential and used only for academic purposes.

Confidentiality:

- All information collected will be kept anonymous.

- No names or personally identifiable information will be used in any report or publication resulting from this research.
- Data will be stored securely and accessed only by the researcher.

Benefits and Risks:

- Your participation may help improve understanding of the relationship between Dark Triad personality traits and money management behaviour. While there are no direct benefits to you, you may request a brief summary of the study's overall findings after its completion. No individual feedback will be provided.
- No significant risks are anticipated; however, reflecting on personality traits related to the Dark Triad and money management behaviour may cause minor emotional discomfort or stress.

Appendix B: Demographic Information & Participant Information Sheet:

Field	Details to Fill In
Participant Code / ID	_____
Name (Optional)	_____
Age	_____ years
Date of Birth	___ / ___ / ___ (Day / Month / Year)
Gender	☐ Male ☐ Female ☐ Non-binary ☐ Transgender ☐ Other ☐ Prefer not to say
Sex Assigned at Birth (Optional)	☐ Male ☐ Female ☐ Intersex ☐ Prefer not to say
Marital Status	☐ Single ☐ Married ☐ Living as Married ☐ Separated ☐ Divorced ☐ Widowed ☐ Prefer not to say ☐ Other: _____
Educational Level (Current)	☐ Undergraduate ☐ Postgraduate ☐ Doctoral ☐ Other: _____

Highest Education Level Completed	☐ None ☐ Primary ☐ Secondary ☐ Tertiary (Bachelor's) ☐ Postgraduate (Master's/M.Phil.) ☐ Doctorate (PhD) ☐ Other: _____
Field of Study / Occupation	_____
Employment Status	☐ Full-time ☐ Part-time ☐ Contract ☐ Intern ☐ Self-employed ☐ Unemployed ☐ Student
Employment Sector	☐ Private ☐ Public ☐ Government ☐ NGO ☐ Start-up ☐ Other: _____
Organization Name (Optional)	_____
Designation / Job Title	_____
Department / Unit	_____
Nature of Work	☐ Technical ☐ Administrative ☐ Managerial ☐ Support Staff ☐ Teaching/Academic ☐ Creative/Design ☐ Customer Service ☐ Sales/Marketing ☐ Healthcare ☐ Finance/Accounts ☐ Human Resources ☐ Research ☐ Other: _____
Work Arrangement	☐ On-site ☐ Hybrid ☐ Remote / Work from Home
Total Years of Work Experience	_____ years
Years in Current Organization	_____ years
Average Weekly Work Hours	_____ hours

Do you supervise others?	☐ Yes ☐ No
Approximate Monthly Personal Income	☐ No income ☐ Below ₹10,000 ☐ ₹10,000–₹25,000 ☐ ₹25,001–₹50,000 ☐ ₹50,001–₹1,00,000 ☐ Above ₹1,00,000
Approximate Monthly Household Income (Optional)	☐ Below ₹25,000 ☐ ₹25,001–₹50,000 ☐ ₹50,001–₹1,00,000 ☐ Above ₹1,00,000 ☐ Prefer not to say
Primary Source of Financial Support	☐ Family ☐ Job/Internship ☐ Scholarship/Stipend ☐ Self-employed ☐ Loans ☐ Other: _____
Financial Responsibility	☐ Only self ☐ Self + family ☐ Family dependent on me ☐ Not financially responsible
Savings Behaviour	☐ Regular saver ☐ Occasional saver ☐ Rarely save ☐ Do not save
Debt Status (Optional)	☐ No debt ☐ Education loan ☐ Personal loan ☐ Credit card debt ☐ Other: _____
Place of Residence	☐ Urban ☐ Semi-urban ☐ Rural
Current Living Arrangement	☐ With parents ☐ With partner ☐ Alone ☐ With roommates ☐ Hostel
Work Location (City/District)	_____
Date	_____
Signature	_____

Your responses will be used for research only and will remain strictly confidential.

Consent Statement:

“I have read and understood the information above. I voluntarily agree to participate in this study. I am aware that I can withdraw at any time without giving any reason and without penalty.”

Participant's Name or Initials *(Optional; disclosure is voluntary and will not be used for identification purposes):* _____

Signature *(Optional; provided at the participant's discretion):*

Date: _____

Researcher's Signature: _____

Date: _____

Appendix C: Instructions for Completing the Questionnaire

This questionnaire consists of two sections assessing **personality traits** and **money-related beliefs and behaviours**. Please read each statement carefully and respond as honestly as possible. There are **no right or wrong answers**.

Please answer all questions based on your **typical behaviour**, not on any single recent experience. If any question makes you uncomfortable, you may skip it. You are free to **withdraw from the study at any time** without any penalty.

All responses will remain **anonymous and confidential** and will be used **only for academic research purposes**.

Scale 1: **For this section**, indicate your level of agreement or disagreement with each statement using the following 5-point scale:

1	2	3	4	5
Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Neither Agree nor Disagree	Agree	Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
1	It is not wise to tell your secrets.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	I like to use clever manipulation to get my way.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Whatever it takes, you must get important people on your side.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	I avoid direct conflict with others because they may be useful in the future.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	It is wise to keep track of information that you can use against people later.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	You should wait for the right time to get back at people.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7	There are things you should hide from other people because they do not need to know.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
8	Make sure your plans benefit you, not others.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
9	Most people can be manipulated.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10	People see me as a natural leader.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

11	I hate being the centre of attention.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
12	Many group activities tend to be dull without me.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
13	I know that I am special because everyone keeps telling me so.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
14	I like to get acquainted with important people.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
15	I feel embarrassed if someone compliments me.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
16	I have been compared to famous people.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
17	I am an average person.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
18	I insist on getting the respect I deserve.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
19	I like to get revenge on authorities.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
20	I avoid dangerous situations.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
21	Payback needs to be quick and nasty.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
22	People often say I am out of control.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
23	It is true that I can be mean to others.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
24	People who mess with me always regret it.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
25	I have never gotten into trouble with the law.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
26	I enjoy having sex with people I hardly know.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
27	I will say anything to get what I want.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Scale 2: For this section, indicate **how often** each statement applies to you using the following **7-point scale**:

Score	Response
1	Never
2	Rarely
3	Occasionally
4	Sometimes
5	Frequently
6	Usually
7	Always

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	I enjoy using money to show people I am successful.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Having more money makes me feel important.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	I like to spend money to make others admire me.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	I would rather give money to gain advantage or influence.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	I feel proud when people see the things I can buy.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	I carefully plan how I will use money in the future.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7	I prefer saving for the future over spending now.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
8	I keep track of what I have so I will be prepared later.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
9	I buy things only after thinking about long-term consequences.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10	I am careful about making financial plans and sticking to them.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
11	I am suspicious of salespeople and marketing offers.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
12	I carefully check prices before I buy.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
13	I do not trust bargains, there is usually a catch.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
14	I worry that I will be taken advantage of financially.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
15	I buy things because I believe quality reflects how I live.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
16	I prefer to spend on well-made things rather than cheap items.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
17	I judge people by the quality of the things they own.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
18	I worry about not having enough money.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
19	I get nervous thinking about my financial future.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
20	Money concerns keep me up at night.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
21	Sometimes I spend impulsively to feel better about money worries.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
22	I feel uneasy if I do not have a financial cushion.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
23	I feel more confident when I have money saved.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

24	I enjoy finding bargains and feel rewarded when I save.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
25	I avoid spending even when it would be reasonable to do so.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
26	I think having money is important for getting respect.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
27	I feel guilty after spending on myself.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
28	I like to lend money to gain goodwill or influence.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
29	I believe careful money habits reflect good character.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Thank You

Thank you for your time and participation in this research study. Your responses are highly valued and will contribute to a better understanding of the relationship between personality traits and money management behaviour.

All information provided will be treated with **strict confidentiality** and will be used **solely for academic and research purposes**.

Your cooperation in completing this questionnaire is sincerely appreciated.

Appendix D: PLAGIARISM REPORT

Page 2 of 47 - Integrity Overview

Submission IDtrn:::3618:136183359

0%Overall Similarity

The combined total of all matches, including overlapping sources, for each database.

Filtered from the Report

- Bibliography
- Quoted Text
- Small Matches (less than 194 words)

Exclusions

- 11 Excluded Matches

Match Groups

0Not Cited or Quoted 0%

Matches with neither in-text citation nor quotation marks

0Missing Quotations 0%

Matches that are still very similar to source material

0Missing Citation 0%

Matches that have quotation marks, but no in-text citation

0Cited and Quoted 0%

Matches with in-text citation present, but no quotation marks

Top Sources

0%Internet sources

0%Publications

0%Submitted works (Student Papers)

Page 2 of 47 - Integrity Overview

Submission IDtrn:::3618:136183359